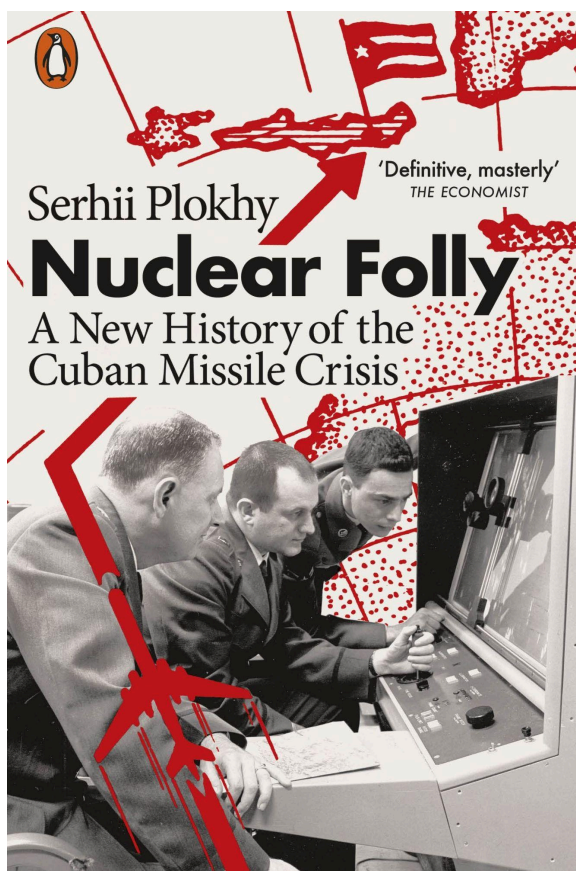




UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE

Social Studies

Invitational A • 2026



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UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE SOCIAL STUDIES CONTEST

INVITATIONAL A • SPRING 2026

Part I: General Knowledge

The Global Cold War and Its Fallout: From Yalta to Malta (1 point each)

1. _____, first proposed by President Ronald Reagan on March 23, 1983, would require extremely advanced technological systems, yet to be developed. Among the potential components of the defense system were both space and earth-based laser battle stations, which, by a combination of methods, would direct their killing beams toward moving Soviet targets.

A. Operation Chrome Dome	C. The Strategic Defense Initiative
B. The Iron Dome	D. The Nike-X program

2. In 1948, the defection of _____ from the Soviet camp struck a severe blow to world Communism as a Stalin-dominated monolith. To prevent others from following the example, Stalin instigated show trials where many satellite Communist leaders confessed to heterodox views and were executed.

A. China	C. Yugoslavia
B. Romania	D. Albania

3. Julius and Ethel Rosenberg were the first U.S. civilians to be executed for conspiracy to commit _____ and the first to suffer that penalty during peacetime.

A. treason	C. espionage
B. sabotage	D. terrorism

4. When President Wilhelm Pieck died in 1960, the office of the presidency of the German Democratic Republic was abolished and subsequently, _____ became chairman of the council of state, thus formally taking supreme power. He crushed all opposition and became so powerful that he was able to block the de-Stalinization movement that swept eastern Europe.

A. Konrad Adenauer	C. Helmut Schmidt
B. Walter Ulbricht	D. Erich Mielke

5. During her term as Prime Minister of Israel, _____ pressed for a peace settlement in the Middle East by diplomatic means. Her meetings included Nicolae Ceaușescu of Romania, Pope Paul VI, and Willy Brandt, chancellor of West Germany.
- | | |
|-----------------|-----------------------|
| A. Tzipi Livini | C. Suzanne Massey |
| B. Golda Meir | D. Shelly Yachimovich |
6. Negotiations with Gamal Abdel Nasser of Egypt and Jawaharlal Nehru of India in 1956 led to a closer cooperation among states that were “nonengaged” in the East-West confrontation. The first large meeting of nonaligned states took place in Belgrade under _____ sponsorship in 1961.
- | | |
|----------------------|-------------------|
| A. Kwame Nkrumah’s | C. Sukarno’s |
| B. Josip Broz Tito’s | D. Fidel Castro’s |
7. On September 26, 1983, just weeks after the Soviet military shot down KAL Flight 007, _____ was the duty officer for the Oko nuclear early-warning system when it reported that five missiles had been launched from the United States. He believed it was a false alarm, and his decision is credited with having prevented a retaliatory nuclear attack.
- | | |
|------------------------|--------------------|
| A. Stanislav Petrov | C. Oleg Gordievsky |
| B. Wojciech Jaruzelski | D. Georgy Zhukov |
8. _____ emerged from the CIA-supported military junta in Guatemala as president in 1954. He removed communist influence, quashed agrarian reform, and broke labor and peasant unions with considerable violence, but he was brought down by an assassin’s bullet in July 1957.
- | | |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------|
| A. Jacobo Árbenz | C. Carlos Castillo Armas |
| B. Anastasio Somoza Debayle | D. Augusto Pinochet |
9. _____ joined a group of army officers that overthrew the Guatemalan dictator Jorge Ubico in 1944, and in 1949, he became the minister of war. In 1951, he became president, supported by the army and left-wing political parties, including the Guatemalan Communist Party.
- | | |
|------------------|----------------------|
| A. Juan Perón | C. Juan José Arévalo |
| B. Jacobo Árbenz | D. Daniel Ortega |
10. Dean Rusk was the U.S. secretary of state during both the _____ administrations and became a target of antiwar hostility as he consistently defended U.S. participation in the Vietnam War.
- | | |
|--------------------------|-------------------------|
| A. Truman and Eisenhower | C. Eisenhower and Nixon |
| B. Nixon and Ford | D. Kennedy and Johnson |

11. Operation _____ was a bombing campaign that began in February 1965 and lasted until the end of October 1968. The operation began primarily as a diplomatic signal to impress Hanoi with the U.S.'s determination and as a warning that it would escalate until Ho Chi Minh 'blinked.'
- A. Rolling Thunder
B. Blue Bat
- C. Urgent Fury
D. Eagle Claw
12. After World War II, _____ commanded the U.S. air forces in Europe, and directed the Berlin airlift in 1948. He headed the U.S. Strategic Air Command from 1948 to 1957 and built it into a global strike force before controversially turning to politics after he retired in 1965.
- A. Lucius D. Clay
B. Curtis LeMay
- C. Francis Gary Powers
D. Allen Dulles
13. The official Chinese view, defined in June 1981, is that _____ leadership was basically correct until the summer of 1957, but from then on it was mixed and frequently wrong. Specifically, the Great Leap and the Cultural Revolution, were ill-conceived and led to disastrous consequences.
- A. Mao Zedong's
B. Zhou Enlai's
- C. Deng Xiaoping's
D. Lin Biao's
14. Egyptian President _____ made a historic visit to Israel in 1977, to present his plan for a peace settlement before the Israeli Knesset. This initiated a series of diplomatic efforts that he continued despite strong opposition from most of the Arab world and the USSR.
- A. Gamal Abdel Nasser
B. Anwar al-Sadat
- C. Enver Hoxa
D. Agostinho Neto
15. _____ was elected mayor of Berlin in 1947, but he was not approved because of Soviet opposition. He did not take office, as mayor of West Berlin, until after the division of the city in 1948. His leadership helped the people of Berlin survive the Soviet blockade.
- A. Willy Brandt
B. Konrad Adenauer
- C. Ernst Reuter
D. Klaus Fuchs
16. Patrice Lumumba was the first prime minister of the Democratic Republic of the Congo. He was forced out of office and was eventually executed by a firing squad under the command of military advisors from _____, the country that had previously colonized his country.
- A. France
B. Portugal
- C. the Netherlands
D. Belgium

17. When the Gold Coast and the British Togoland trust territory became an independent state within the British Commonwealth as Ghana in 1957, _____ became the new nation's first prime minister.

- | | |
|-------------------|--------------------|
| A. Haile Selassie | C. Kwame Nkrumah |
| B. Holden Roberto | D. Ahmed Ben Bella |

18. After Josef Stalin died in 1953, _____ resumed the post of foreign minister for the USSR until disagreements with Nikita Khrushchev resulted in his dismissal in 1956. He was made minister of state control, but when he joined the "antiparty group" that unsuccessfully tried to depose Khrushchev in June 1957, he lost all his high party and state offices.

- | | |
|-----------------------|-------------------|
| A. Georgi Malenkov | C. Yuri Andropov |
| B. Vyacheslav Molotov | D. Lavrenti Beria |

- Special Representative to mediate the Chinese Civil War
- Member of the Joint Chief of Staff
- Secretary of State
- Secretary of Defense

19. All of the items listed above were positions held by _____ during the Truman administration.

- | | |
|-----------------------|--------------------|
| A. Ernest Bevin | C. George Marshall |
| B. John Foster Dulles | D. Dean Acheson |

20. In the campaign for the first parliamentary elections of the new _____ republic in 1948, the U.S. provided backing for the Christian Democrats and their partners. Anti-Communist propaganda, excommunication of Communists by the Catholic Church, and CIA-financed efforts dominated the campaign. The Christian Democrats won over half the seats, but less than half the vote.

- | | |
|------------|-----------|
| A. German | C. Polish |
| B. Italian | D. Korean |

Part II: Primary Source Material

Nuclear Folly: A History of the Cuban Missile Crisis, by Serhii Plokhyy

(2 points each)

21. The news that the Soviets were bringing intermediate-range missiles to Cuba that could cover most of the U.S. strengthened President Kennedy's advocacy of a(n) _____. He had taken that position during the first day of the crisis. He stated that congressional resolutions gave him all the authority he needed and according to John McCone he "seemed inclined to act."
- A. complete blockade of all war-related materials
 - B. airstrike that would take out both Castro and any missiles
 - C. unannounced strike on the Soviet missile sites
 - D. joint naval and air bombardment of Cuba
22. In June 1962, _____ came to the attention of the Communist Party Presidium for his role in suppressing the revolt in the city of Novocherkassk.
- A. Anatoly Gribkov
 - B. Leonid Garbuz
 - C. Issa Pliev
 - D. Igor Statsenko
23. On October 22, 1962, Khrushchev summoned the Presidium to the Kremlin to discuss "positions toward further steps in regard to Cuba and _____." In fact, the only item discussed that night in the Kremlin was Cuba. The other headline topic was not mentioned even once.
- A. Turkey
 - B. Italy
 - C. Latin America
 - D. Berlin
24. On May 4, 1961, Andrei Gromyko summoned Llewellyn Thompson to his office in Moscow and told him the "Cuban crisis" had shown the need to build bridges between the U.S. and USSR. On May 16th, Khrushchev proposed to Kennedy a place and time for a summit: _____, June 3, 1961.
- A. Vienna
 - B. New York
 - C. Warsaw
 - D. Potsdam
25. Khrushchev's first reaction to the U.S.'s _____ was to state, "That's it. Lenin's work has been destroyed," and the mood in the Kremlin was close to panic according to KGB chief, Vladimir Semichastny.
- A. U-2 pilot being shot down over Cuba
 - B. discovery of missiles in Cuba
 - C. refusal to remove missiles in Turkey
 - D. intercepted plans for a Cuban invasion

26. Khrushchev asked General Aleksei Dementiev, “What do you think: can the deployment of our rockets in Cuba be kept secret?” The General replied “_____.”
- A. No. That is impossible.
 - B. Of course, secrets are our business
 - C. Yes, with much hard work and more luck.
 - D. Only with complete cooperation from Castro.
27. On October 16th, as discussions progressed, President Kennedy had four options in mind: a surgical air strike; a general air strike; a general strike with a naval blockade; or diplomacy. Robert Kennedy reminded him of a fifth option: _____.
- A. removing NATO missiles
 - B. accepting the new situation
 - C. going to the United Nations
 - D. the invasion of Cuba
28. The 37 year-old Colonel _____, who commanded an infantry regiment and was sent to Cuba to protect the missile installations aboard the *Victory*, would become the last Soviet Minister of Defense under Mikhail Gorbachev.
- A. Mikhail Tokarenko
 - B. Ivan Pismenny
 - C. Ivan Sidorov
 - D. Dmitrii Yazov
29. On October 25, 1962, President Kennedy tried to use _____ to pass a message to Fidel Castro. He told the Algerian leader that he was prepared to make peace with the “national communist” regime as long as Castro did not try to challenge the status quo in Latin America.
- A. Kwame Nkrumah
 - B. Patrice Lumumba
 - C. Julius Nyerere
 - D. Ahmed Ben Bella
30. Hervé Alphand, the French Ambassador in Washington, asked Dean Rusk about Khrushchev’s change of positions and was shown his letter of October 26th to Kennedy. Alphand remarked that it “showed _____.”
- A. signs of a power struggle
 - B. symptoms of hysteria
 - C. calm and cool logic
 - D. a shocking lack of understanding

31. According to the account presented in Robert Kennedy's memoirs, his brother brought up Barbara Tuchman's *Guns of August* saying, "They somehow seemed to tumble into ____ through stupidity, individual idiosyncrasies, misunderstandings, and personal complexes of inferiority and grandeur."
- A. World War II
B. the Cold War
C. World War I
D. the Korean War
32. President Kennedy considered the missiles in Italy and Turkey worthless because since they required ____, they invited an attack instead of deterring one.
- A. fifteen to twenty minutes to prepare
B. a cleared area that was easily observable
C. thousands of support troops
D. massive nearby fuel depots
33. Khrushchev was convinced that the U.S. was invading Cuba and if the attack happened, he had two response scenarios he was considering. One option was to declare on the radio that there was already an agreement to defend Cuba. This was to warn the U.S. that escalating would risk a wider war. The other option was to declare that ____.
- A. Berlin would officially be under East German control
B. all equipment was Cuban and the Cubans would respond
C. NATO missile sites within 100 miles of the USSR would be attacked
D. Soviet submarines would descend on Cuba and deploy a blockade
34. According to Serhii Plokyh, with the signing in August 1963 of the ____ Treaty, Kennedy and Khrushchev saved the world a second time by drastically limiting radioactive fallout which threatened life on the planet as we know it.
- A. International Outer Space
B. Nuclear Non-Proliferation
C. Partial Nuclear Test-Ban
D. Comprehensive Nuclear Test-Ban
35. In September 1969, the *Ilia Mechnikov* delivered the first-ever shipment of Soviet weapons to Cuba. In October 1973, long after its Cuban service, the *Ilia Mechnikov* was sunk by rocket fire while visiting the Syrian port of Tartus during the ____.
- A. Six Day War
B. Yom Kippur War
C. Suez Crisis
D. invasion of Afghanistan

Part III: Supplemental Readings
(3 points each)

36. The _____ was founded in 1956, with the help of the clandestine Portuguese Communist Party, and from 1962, it was led by Agostinho Neto. It was popular in Luanda and among some rural Mbundu, drawing foreign support from the Soviet Union.
- A. UNITA
B. MPLA
C. FNLA
D. ANC
37. In 1963, the Ngos became embroiled in a fatal quarrel with the _____ leadership in South Vietnam. A monk, Thich Quang Duc, publicly doused himself with gasoline and set himself ablaze as a protest against Diem's repression. After raids by the government on pagodas, a group of generals secretly met with the U.S. to gauge its reaction to a coup to remove Diem.
- A. Viet Cong
B. Catholic
C. Buddhist
D. Viet Minh
38. In Ho Chi Minh's 1967 letter responding to President Lyndon Johnson's request for negotiations, the North Vietnamese leader states that talks could only occur if the U.S. "first of all, stop unconditionally _____" in the Democratic Republic of Vietnam.
- A. its bombing raids
B. mining Haiphong harbor
C. incursions across the 17th parallel
D. threatening use of nuclear arms
39. The white paper produced by the U.S. State Department on February 27, 1965, asserts that the "total political and military effort" of the Viet Cong is directly controlled by the _____.
- A. USSR's Politburo
B. People's Liberation Army of China
C. Khmer Rouge of Cambodia
D. North Vietnamese Communist Party
40. In 1948, the Allied powers decided to unite their different occupation zones of Germany into a single economic unit. They then introduced _____ in West Berlin and West Germany. The Soviets responded by beginning a blockade of all rail, road, and water communications to West Berlin.
- A. nuclear armed missiles
B. the deutsche mark
C. NATO garrisons
D. parliamentary elections

“There never was a war in history easier to prevent by timely action than the one which has just desolated such great areas of the globe. It could have been prevented, in my belief, without the firing of a single shot...but no one would listen and one by one we were sucked into the awful whirlpool.”

41. The statement above made by Winston Churchill in Fulton Missouri refers to _____.
A. the Cold War
B. World War II
C. the Korean War
D. the Greek Civil War
42. NSC-68 states that “it would be to the long-term advantage of the U.S. if atomic weapons were to be effectively eliminated from national peacetime armaments,” but “in the absence of such elimination and the securing of these objectives,” the only alternative would be to _____.
A. increase the stockpile of atomic weapons as quickly as possible
B. strike a surprise blow on the USSR before they gain atomic superiority
C. develop bases throughout the world to avoid a centralized target
D. create atomic programs in NATO countries and for future allies
43. The U.S. military argued for an air strike to destroy Soviet missiles in Cuba, followed by an invasion while others favored warnings. President Kennedy ordered a naval “_____” on October 22nd. This was legally distinguished from a blockade, which assumed a state of war existed.
A. embargo
B. isolation
C. siege
D. quarantine
- “Such ‘self-determination’ as a result of which NATO troops would have been able to come up to the Soviet border, while the community of European socialist countries would have been split, in effect encroaches upon the vital interests of the peoples of these countries...”*
44. The quote above comes from _____ in November 1968, in response to events in Czechoslovakia.
A. Alexander Dubček
B. Antonín Novotný
C. Gustáv Husák
D. Leonid Brezhnev
45. The 1964 “Gulf of Tonkin” Resolution gave the president of the United States the ability to determine all necessary steps to assist any member of the _____ requesting assistance in defense.
A. SEATO
B. NATO
C. CENTO
D. GATT

ESSAY PROMPT:

NOTE: Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified. Any essay that does not demonstrate a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic will be disqualified. The rankings of essays will be based primarily on how well the topic has been addressed. A focused, concise and specific essay beats a vague and rambling essay. Proper grammar and organization should be used to aid clarity, but should not be considered a major factor in scoring. Cover as many corners of the issue as practical. Avoid including personal editorialized opinions, as more than enough information on the subject has been published.

“Between 1944 and 1947, Soviet policies in eastern Europe gave rise to much conflict with the United States and Britain. But American and British policies-in part in response to Moscow’s behavior in the east-also helped convince Stalin that only through Communist regimes could Soviet control of eastern Europe be made secure.”

“By the spring of 1947, many Europeans and most U.S. policy-makers had become fixated on a seemingly relentless pattern of Soviet expansionism in eastern Europe...In the west, many who had lived through the 1930s noted similarities with Nazi expansionism. And there was the scale of it: Soviet control seemed to be imposing itself over half of Europe.

-Odd Arne Westad, “The Cold War: A World History”

The exact beginning of the Cold War is not historically agreed on, but by 1947 the countries of Europe were fully embroiled in what the world was beginning to recognize as a struggle for their political and economic futures. Describe the major political, economic, and social developments in Europe from 1947-1955, that set the stage for the future of the Cold War.

UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE
SOCIAL STUDIES CONTEST
 SET A • 2026
ANSWER KEY

Part I (1 point each)	Part II (2 points each)	Points contestants could mention in their essay:	
1. C	21. C (pg. 147)	Background	of police forces and Stalin's increased control such as denying Marshall funds.
2. C	22. C (pg. 78)	•Churchill delivered his "Sinews of Peace" speech in March 1946, in Missouri declaring that an Iron Curtain was dividing Europe into two camps.	•The GDR was founded in Oct. '49 in reaction to the creation of the FRG, but was not recognized in the West. After Stalin's death in March '53, East Germans rioted against Ulbricht's harsh rule in June, but were defeated after Soviet troops invaded to support Ulbricht's regime.
3. C	23. D (pg. 163)	•The UK announced that it could no longer continue supporting Greek and Turkish efforts against communist insurgencies. Truman asked Congress on March 12, 1947, for \$400 million to support "containment" efforts in what became the Truman Doctrine.	•Yugoslavia under Tito was expelled from Cominform in June 1948, and would receive aid from the West. It became a supporter/leader of the Non-Aligned Movement at the Bandung Conf. in '55.
4. B	24. A (pg. 23)	•The harsh winter and low crop yields experienced in 1946-47 led to shortages and rationing that exceeded wartime constraints in some countries.	Capitalist governments
5. B	25. B (pg. 166)	•The Economic Recovering Plan was signed on April 3, 1948, after being proposed by George Marshall on June 5, 1947. It would provide over \$13 billion in aid to Europe to shore up economies and create political stability.	•In April '48, Italy elected a Christian Democrats-led government over the Communist-led Popular Front helped by the Catholic church and the CIA's efforts.
6. B	26. A (pg. 72)	•The USSR would counter with Comecon in 1949, to aid Communist countries that it forbade from taking Marshall funds.	•US/UK/France introduce the Deutsche Mark in W. Berlin and the USSR responded w/ a blockade days later in June '48. The Allied Airlift "Operation Vittles" forced the blockade open by May '49, followed immediately by the creation of the Fed. Republic of Germany.
7. A	27. D (pg. 138)	Communist governments	•NATO was founded in April '49 with mainly W. European members (Belg., Lux., Den, France, UK, Neth., Nor., Port, Iceland) w/ the US & Canada
8. C	28. D (pg. 91)	•On Dec. 30, 1947, Romania's King Michael I was forced to abdicate and the Communist Party merged with other leftist groups to great one-party rule under a new constitution in April 1948. The Soviet-occupied nations of Bulgaria, Poland, and Hungary all similarly established Communist rule by 1949. Albania under Hoxha had been communist since '46.	•Greece would end their civil war by Oct. '49 and join NATO with Turkey in '52. When West Germany was added in May '55, the Communist countries immediately responded by forming the Warsaw Pact w/ 8 founding members.
9. B	29. D (pg. 133)	•Klement Gottwald led a coup in Czechoslovakia in Feb. '48 after non-communists resigned in protest to increased Communist control	•Austria would have its post-war occupation by US and USSR troops ended in October '55 when it declared neutrality.
10. D	30. B (pg. 300)		
11. A	31. C (pg. 178)		
12. B	32. A (pg. 217)		
13. A	33. B (pg. 165)		
14. B	34. C (pg. 359)		
15. C	35. B (pg. 85)		
16. D	Part III (3 points each)		
17. C	36. B		
18. B	37. C		
19. C	38. A		
20. B	39. D		
	40. B		
	41. B		
	42. A		
	43. D		
	44. D		
	45. A		